

statement or disclosure statement, depending on which state or territory you're in, comes to the fore as a safeguard for both buyer and seller.

Importantly, the vendor's statement is not worth the paper it is written on unless it is signed by the vendor. Usually it is prepared by the vendor's lawyer, or conveyancer, and supplied to the real estate agent, who makes it available to prospective buyers. The buyer *must* read this document, or hire a legal pro on their behalf to do so, before signing the contract. As the saying goes, 'The devil is in the detail.'

By law, a person selling real estate must disclose information in their vendor's statement that affects what they're selling; information that is vital to the intended buyer. In lay terms, this document discloses what is not necessarily apparent to a prospective buyer who strolls through, takeaway latte in hand, during a weekend 'open for inspection'. This can include the zoning of the property (e.g. residential), the connected services (water, gas and electricity), a copy of the title and a copy of the plan, and for those buying an apartment, townhouse or unit, any necessary body corporate or owners' corporation information.

The buyer needs to make sure that the title proves the vendor has the right to sell the property and that the title corresponds exactly with your expectations of what you're buying. Some statements include a council valuation on the property, which is used for rates assessment. If yours doesn't, it's worth taking the time to contact the council for its most recent valuation. If you haven't hired a professional, licensed valuer, this figure becomes a guide to the value of the property, although not always an accurate one, and is often more conservative than market value. In any case, booking an independent valuation will add another piece of information to the puzzle.

The buyer should also raise questions about any recent renovations that have been undertaken on the property, and ask for relevant permits. Be diligent in this regard.

Apartments, townhouses and units

In the case of buying these properties, it is important to be aware of the ongoing costs, particularly body corporate fees. Inner-city body corporate fees can range from \$3000 to \$10,000 per year, calculated based on amenities such as swimming pools and gymnasiums, how many lifts there